

# Beer, Rails, Iron, Coal (BRIC)

**Difficulty:** **Easy**

**Strong at all player counts.**

The goal of this strategy is to get a decent base of points in the canal era, then dominate the rail era with high-value rails, beer and iron.

## Canal Era Goals

- Build two level 2 manufacturers and sell them using two level 2 breweries.
- Build your level 2 & 3 iron works. Building level 4 is powerful, but risks a later overbuild.
- Position yourself to go first in the rail era by spending no money in the last round of the canal era (take loan and sell), and as little money as possible in the second to last round.
- Although risky, building a 3rd brewery will set you well ahead if it is used in the canal era. If not, make sure you go first in the rail era to double-rail!
- In fact, an alternate BRIC approach is to build all four breweries and no manufacturers at all! If no one uses your beer, double-rail twice on the first turn in the rail era!

## Rail Era Goals

- Build as many breweries as you can. Build a brewery with your first action, then use your second action to double-rail.
- Build as many high-value rails as you can. Double rail as often as possible.
- Build your level 4 iron work. Do not be afraid to give away free iron.

# Big Cotton

**Difficulty:** **Medium**

**Strongest at 2p, strong at all player counts.**

The goal of this strategy is to develop away your low level cotton mills to play high-yielding level 3 and 4 cotton mills, scoring massive points from industries. However, two players pursuing this strategy in a 3/4p often goes poorly for both.

## Canal Era Goals

- Build three level 3 cotton mills and sell them using market beer & other player's beer. In a pinch, build a level 1 brewery.
- Alternatively, build two level 3 cotton mills and sell them using two level 2 breweries.
- Try to build very few canals, 2 or 3 maximum. Make use of other players' links to the market.
- Build coal mines to offset your loans in the same locations as other players' iron works. This way, you can save actions by not placing canals and earn money & income while other players compete for limited iron locations.

## Rail Era Goals

- Secure a farm brewery location to build and sell at the end of the rail era.
- Compete for high-value rails in the beginning of the rail era, then pivot to building industries.
- Be wary of relying on others to link to the markets for you. If you plan on selling three or more industries, you cannot afford more than 6 rails.
- Build at least 2 or 3 coal mines to ensure a high income. The more industries you plan on building, the higher income you need.

# Pottery

**Difficulty:** **Hard**

**Strong at all player counts.**

The goal of this strategy is to build and sell all your high-yielding pottery. This is a high-risk-high-reward strategy because it is easily blocked and unforgiving after a botched canal era. It should only be pursued if you have favorable location cards for pottery and breweries and favorable market locations.

## Canal Era Goals

- Build and sell your level 1 and 3 pottery in the canal era. Use as much of your own beer as you can.
- Build either iron or coal to maintain your income. Building iron is worth more points, and if there is a market shortage, will also give good money!
- If you cannot make iron or coal effectively, sell your level 1 pottery with a level 2 brewery early to reset loans and benefit from the income.
- If you are nervous about being blocked, you can secure the location with a level 2 pottery and then overbuild it with your level 3. However, the most efficient approach is to develop twice, once for your level 1 breweries and once for your level 1 coal and your level 2 pottery.

## Rail Era Goals

- Compete for high-value rails, iron and breweries to round out your strategy.
- Build your level 4 or 5 pottery quickly so that you do not lose the location to someone's level 1 pottery.
- Secure a farm brewery location to build and sell at the end of the rail era.

# Big Box

**Difficulty:** **Hard**

**Viable at 3p and 4p.**

The goal of this strategy is to develop away your low level manufacturers to play level 5, 6 and 7 manufacturers, scoring massive points from industries. Alternatively, build rails around a single city before filling it with level 5 “boxes.” This strategy works best against two BRIC players, but is still considered worse than BRIC or Big Cotton.

## Canal Era Goals

- Build one level 5 and one level 6 manufacturers and sell them. Alternatively, build one level 2 and one level 5 manufacturers.
- Use at least two of your own beer, if possible.
- Choose how often you should develop boxes based on the iron market. The more expensive iron is, the less appealing it is to continually develop for higher level boxes.
- Although iron is worth more points, coal requires less actions for a higher income.
- Alternatively, play the canal era just like BRIC, then surround a city with rails in the rail era and build level 5 manufacturers inside it to maximize the value of each rail!

## Rail Era Goals

- Compete for high-value rails in the beginning of the rail era. When the 6+ point rails are gone, pivot to building level 6, 7 & 8 manufacturers and your level 1 pottery.
- Alternatively, play the rail era just like BRIC, but surround a city with rails in the and build level 5 manufacturers inside it to maximize the value of each rail!

# Low Cotton

**Difficulty:** **Very Hard**

**Viable at 3p and 4p.**

The goal of this strategy is to build low-level cotton in order to sell lots of beer and have very high income going into the rail era. Then, dominate the rail era with beer, rails and iron. This strategy is experimental and does not have a high win rate!

## Canal Era Goals

- Build three level 1 cotton mills and/or manufacturers and sell them using your own level 2 & 3 breweries.
- Try to build very few canals, 2 or 3 maximum. Make use of other players’ links to the market.
- Build coal mines to offset your loans in the same locations as other players’ iron works. This way, you can save actions by not placing canals and earn money while other players compete for limited iron locations.

## Rail Era Goals

- Build as many breweries as you can. Build a brewery with your first action, then use your second action to double-rail.
- Build as many high-value rails as you can. Double rail as often as possible.
- Build your level 4 iron work. Do not be afraid to give away free iron.

# Tips

## General Tips

- Your most precious resource is your actions. Each action should gain you about 5 points.
- Develop away all level 1 industries you plan on building (except either iron or coal to overbuild).
- Choose your strategy based on your cards and market demand locations.

## Canal Era Tips

- If you are first to act in the canal era, take a loan. You will be first to act next round and can build an iron work to great profit!
- Take loans into negative income, since they are easier to bounce back from. But “reset” your loans quickly with iron works or coal mines to avoid losing too much money!
- If you don’t build iron or coal first, you will likely have a hard time resetting your loans.
- It is a good idea to overbuild your own level 1 iron/coal to reset a loan instead of building another canal. This saves you precious actions!
- Brewery locations are precious and can be stolen. Save your beer cards until you have built your breweries, or know they won’t be taken.

## Rail Era Tips

- In the beginning of the rail era, secure as many high value links and beer locations as you can!
- If you go last, look to take a loan or scout to go first and take 4 actions in a row. Beer, loan, double-rail, double-rail is a game winning move!
- Build and sell level 1 pottery towards the end of the rail era
- If you need beer to sell industries, but all brewery locations are taken, consider overbuilding your own brewery to sell on the last turn.